The evolution of money

People originally traded surplus commodities with each other in a process known as bartering. The value of each good traded could be debated, however, and money evolved as a practical solution to the complexities of bartering hundreds of different things. Over the centuries, money has appered in many forms, but, whatever shape it takes, whether as a coin, a note, or stored on a digital server, money always provides a fixed value against which any item can be compared.

The ascent of money

Money has become increasingly complex over time. What began as a means of recording trade exchanges, then appeared in the form of coins and notes, is now primarily digital.

Barter
(10,000–3000BCE)
In early forms of trading, specific items were exchanged for others agreed by the negotiating parties to be of similar value. *See pp.14–15*

Evidence of trade records
(7000BCE)
Pictures of items were used to record trade exchanges, becoming more complex as values were established and documented. *See pp.16–17*

Coinage
(600BCE–1100CE)
Defined weights of precious metals used by some merchants were later formalized as coins that were usually issued by states. *See pp.16–17*